

Ottoman expansion
Suleyman the Magnificent (1494–1566) at the Battle of Mohacs in 1526 *(above)* and a 17th-century Ottoman helmet *(right)*. Under Suleyman's leadership, the Ottoman Empire reached its Golden Age and became a world power. He led Ottoman armies to conquer Belgrade, Rhodes, and most of Hungary, laid the Siege of Vienna, and annexed much of the Middle East.

AT THE START OF THE 16TH CENTURY the army of the Turkish Ottoman Empire was probably the most effective fighting force in the world. It was a unique mix of different kinds of fighting men, well rewarded and organized, and with high morale as a result of an unbroken string of victories. The most famous element in the Ottoman army were the janissaries, slave-soldiers trained from a young age who formed an infantry elite, but cavalry and artillery played just as important a role in the sultan's wars against Christian and Muslim powers.

The Ottomans originated as a band of a few hundred Turkish ghazis – fierce Muslim tribal warriors – who established control over an area of Anatolia during the 13th century. They were neighbours of the Byzantine Empire, still a major state but by then entering an advanced stage of disintegration. Under Osman (who ruled 1281 to 1326) and his successors, the Ottomans exploited Byzantine weakness to infiltrate into Europe, taking over the Balkans in the course of the 14th century. They finally seized the Byzantine capital, Constantinople, in 1453 and made it the centre of their empire. In the 16th century their armies penetrated Christian Europe up to the walls of Vienna, while they also battled the Persian Safavids and the Egyptian Mamluks, taking control of North Africa and much of the Middle East. These extraordinary wide-ranging conquests were achieved by a military system that exploited the best of a number of different fighting traditions and technologies.

GOOD LEARNERS

Initially, the Ottomans fought in the style of steppe horsemen. They were mounted archers using the composite bow as their main weapon and generally avoiding close-quarters combat. Swift-moving, missile-armed cavalry would remain an important element of Ottoman forces throughout the peak years of their empire, but they could not have achieved the success they did without developing highly effective heavy cavalry, infantry, and artillery, as well as creating their own navy. One of the most striking aspects of Ottoman rule in the 15th and 16th centuries was the vigour with which they adapted to new ways of making war. A European observer commented that "no nation has shown less reluctance to adopt the useful inventions of others". The Ottomans mimicked Christian Europe in the adoption of firearms, progressing from the arquebus, via the matchlock musket, to the flintlock (although they never created Euopean-style bodies of pikemen). They were similarly swift to equip their army with cannon, initially by purchasing the skills of European experts. Mehmed the Conqueror famously employed a Hungarian, known as Urban, to found the great guns with which he battered the walls of Constantinople in 1453. Although the Ottomans became renowned for their use of extra large cannon in siege warfare, they did not neglect lighter field artillery, which always formed an effective part of their armies.

COMPLEX FORCES

The forces of the mature Ottoman Empire centred around a standing army of household soldiers in the direct pay of the sultan. These permanent forces included the sultan's elite infantry bodyguard, the janissaries, who at least until the late 17th century were slave-soldiers, and non-slave cavalry. When the sultan embarked on a military campaign, this relatively small regular army was augmented by provincial forces raised through the *timar* system, which was in some ways akin to European feudalism. Horsemen known as *sipahis* were given the right to raise rent from an area of land in return for military duties. They were required to present themselves for service along with a certain number of their followers, equipped for war, at the bidding of the sultan.



RAWHIDE CHICHAK (HELMET) WITH COPPER GILT